are there are several exclusions. My father-in-law's stroke was not covered for, we had to bear the treatment cost, which was steep," says Rashi.

In the Shastri household, Rama's father needed hospitalisation for two weeks months before he died and that set her back by over Rs 10 lakh. "We had stopped taking insurance for him once he turned 72 and had undergone a bypass because that experience was bitter with the insurer," she adds. However, not all health insurance experiences are bad. Patil is thankful that his employer-provided family insurance came in handy when he had to get his

**DON'T DO ALL THE WORK YOURSELF AND MAKE SURE EVERYONE IN THE HOUSEHOLD HAS AGE-APPROPRIATE JOBS AND TASKS ASSIGNED TO THEM, AND THEY COMPLETE THEM**

father and mother operated on for cataracts. "When the doctor told my father that he will need a cataract surgery, I was devastated at the thought of not having the money for it. Thankfully, the health insurance covered for most of the expenses and we just had to shell out a little," he says.

The experience of having insurance, both life and health, has come to the rescue of many families and ignoring it is not a wise move. Once insurance needs are addressed, one should focus on debt servicing and reducing it. Servicing debt is like paying a portion of what you earn even before it hits into your account.

"I was highly influenced by my father's ways of saving and managing the household within our means. That doesn't mean he was stingy. It was just that we knew the difference between needs and wants," says Seshadri. The early money lessons learnt have come in handy for him; he has been conservative on spending, and the fact that his spouse is also employed ensured that the additional income source was deployed towards investments. "We practically rebuilt our house 15 years ago after nearly four decades of living in it to suit the changing times and added a floor," he adds.

In the case of Patil, his father was a man of limited means, which meant he and his brother had to plan for their future largely on their own. "My brother is six years older than me, which was good in many ways because he acted as a cushion for me in many things," he says. He funded his college education, for instance. He also owes him for sharing the bulk of the expenses towards managing his parents.

Sandwich Generation homes can face serious financial issues, especially when managing day-to-day routine expenses. These are homes where a budget is a must and knowing where the money goes is essential, even if affordability is not an issue. "We maintain a clear expense sheet between Uday and me, which allows us to know where we are spending, and how much is needed to run our household," explains Rashi. Although her parents do not stay with her, she oversees their finances because her father easily forgets where he spends his money these days due to age.

### BALANCING ACT

For even those who do not live in a multi-generation house, balancing home and work is already

# COPING WITH FINANCIAL STRESS

**Money problems can cause anxiety, stress and sometimes severe mental health issues. Get help and resolve your financial problems before they go out of hand**

Late in 2019, Tilak Raj quit his well-paying job to join his friends to start their own venture. At 46, this veteran techie had seen recession cycles, and had work stints in East Asia, Europe and the US. His financial life was stable with his spouse working as a senior vice president at a data analytics consultancy. His two school-going children in the tony global school near their apartment were happy and well-settled.

And, then Covid happened. Despite all the plans he had set for himself to use his savings for a year before expecting any money from the start-up, Raj was worried. The lockdowns and uncertainties added to his woes and when his new venture took off slowly, he worried more than he could handle. "I was financially prudent after the first time I faced the impact of recession and job loss in 2000. But, Covid triggered some uncomfortable old memories," he recounts.

Although financially his family was secure and sound, Tilak started expecting the worst and questioning every expense. His wife Gayatri, who had by far been conservative, felt that Tilak was being unrealistic in running their household during the lockdown phase. "He would get worked up every time I extended a little more cash to the maid, who had been working for us for five years, despite her not coming to work," she recounts. She quickly realised something wasn't right with her otherwise generous and level-headed husband.

Gayatri scheduled a talk with their